

Crysis 2 AI

Crytek claims their new game Crysis 2 will have the best AI in any game

Starcraft II pre-loaded

Blizzard has enabled pre-loading of the upcoming strategy game Starcraft II

International Cricket 2010



This game is a little rough around the edges; however it is quite solid where it really matters

Codemasters has followed up Cricket Ashes 2009 with release of the next game in the series called International Cricket 2010.

While in most part, the game is the same as the last release, in some areas it is a step up. When it comes to sheen and presentation, this game is far from sport games by the likes of EA Sports. However, considering the dearth of Cricket video games in general, International Cricket 2010 is perhaps as good as it gets in its space.

Meat of the game

For the unlicensed teams, the players are given names that are just different enough not to violate any rights, but at the same time they are obvious enough to hint at their real-life equivalent. For instance, Virender Sehwag goes by the name of V. Sevak in the game.

The skills of players in the game closely match those of their real-life counterparts. In addition to this however, each time a player reaches a certain milestone in the game (like a certain number of boundaries) the game rewards a skills point to that player. This skill point can then be used to upgrade that player's skill. The various skills of a cricketer are distributed under three main categories of batting, bowling and fielding. The cumulative skills of all the players in a team determine the overall ability of a team in these three

categories and its star rating.

This game also has good variety of options when it comes to match types. It features 20 over matches, one day international (ODI) and Test matches. The ODI can be further customised to setup 5, 10, 25 or 50 over matches. Then there are four types of preset tournaments – World 20 overs, Champions Cup (ODI), 20 overs Super League and World Trophy (ODI). In addition to this, the game also has the option to create custom tournaments.

On the field

Players' performance is dependent on their skills in the three key areas (balling, batting and fielding), coupled with their current level of confidence. In turn, players' confidence is built up by good performance on the field. What this boils down to is that typically one would start with safe simple stuff before trying high-risk, high-payout moves. Bowling and batting techniques are masterfully mapped to the gamepad without making things too complicated.

Batsmen have three stroke types available: defensive, attacking and loft and the power and direction of the stroke is controlled by the analogue stick. In addition, a batsman can choose to play the stroke on the back-foot, front-foot or step-up ahead of the crease. For the bowler, there is a wider variety of options

THE SKOAR

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Genre: Sports

Studio: Trickstar Games

Publishers: Codemasters

***Platforms:** PlayStation 3, Xbox 360

Price: Rs. 1,999

***Reviewed on** Xbox 360

and techniques available. A bowler can choose the length of the balling pitch, type and amount of swing or spin to the ball and also choose to aim the ball at the stumps or outside its range. The variety of options available depends on the bowlers' skills and how much the ball is worn.

Fielding is largely automated with the exception of catching and throwing. When a fielder has an opportunity to catch a ball, the game slows down to bullet time, with a coloured circle around the ball. During this time, the player needs to press a key at the exact moment the circle turns green, in order to successfully make the catch.

Dumpy pitch

This game starts taking a hit on quality when it comes to things like presentation and animation. While the commentary is dry and dreary—like it generally is even in real-life—the commentary lines are quite limited and they repeat more often than it usually does in a sports video game. There are also commonly occurring animation glitches, especially outside of the pitch area. There is also a major problem with appeals to the umpire. It is quite common for the players to appeal for an LBW, even when the batsman is cleaned bowled. Additionally, the developers could have done a lot better with the menu and navigation system. Editing a player's skills, gear and appearance is a tedious process that could have been easily avoided by a better designed system.

All things considered, International Cricket 2010 culminates into a fairly solid product. The variety of option available in single-player modes is complemented by an equally decent number of multiplayer options. The game supports two to four player offline multiplayer and two-player online matches. We must say that we actually find this sport to be extremely mind-numbing in real life. 